

Crisis Stabilization & Safety Planning

Learner guide | SWP-006 | School of Mental Health & Clinical Practice

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Crisis Stabilization & Safety Planning. By the end of the course, you should be able to respond to acute distress using de-escalation, risk assessment, and collaborative safety planning.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Respond to acute distress using de-escalation, risk assessment, and collaborative safety planning.
- Apply the key ideas from Crisis recognition and triage.
- Apply the key ideas from De-escalation and engagement.
- Apply the key ideas from Safety planning and follow-up.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Crisis recognition and triage	acute risk, protective factors, emergency thresholds, and local escalation routes	10 to 15 minutes
2. De-escalation and engagement	communication, environment, grounding, and maintaining professional boundaries	10 to 15 minutes
3. Safety planning and follow-up	warning signs, coping actions, contacts, means-safety discussion, documentation, and warm handover	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Crisis recognition and triage

This module focuses on acute risk, protective factors, emergency thresholds, and local escalation routes. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Acute risk
- Protective factors
- Emergency thresholds
- Local escalation routes

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of crisis recognition and triage in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of acute risk, protective factors, emergency thresholds, and local escalation routes. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through crisis recognition and triage safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 De-escalation and engagement

This module focuses on communication, environment, grounding, and maintaining professional boundaries. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Communication
- Environment
- Grounding
- Maintaining professional boundaries

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of de-escalation and engagement in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of communication, environment, grounding, and maintaining professional boundaries. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through de-escalation and engagement safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Safety planning and follow-up

This module focuses on warning signs, coping actions, contacts, means-safety discussion, documentation, and warm handover. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Warning signs
- Coping actions
- Contacts
- Means-safety discussion
- Documentation
- Warm handover

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of safety planning and follow-up in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of warning signs, coping actions, contacts, means-safety discussion, documentation, and warm handover. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through safety planning and follow-up safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: triage.
- Review the distinction between: de-escalation.
- Review the distinction between: safety-plan elements.
- Review the distinction between: referral thresholds.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.